

Diaspora Dynamics: Methodological Innovations in Community-Based Research for Crisis Response

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Abstract

Diaspora communities play an increasingly significant role in humanitarian crisis response, yet traditional research methodologies often fall short in capturing their nuanced experiences. This paper addresses the critical need for innovative, culturally-sensitive research approaches by reporting on a study involving eight community researchers (CRs) from diverse diaspora backgrounds. Given significant methodological autonomy, CRs investigated crisis response within their communities, revealing dynamic adaptations of traditional research methods, creative leveraging of technology, and navigation of complex dual identities. These adaptations led to more authentic engagement and richer insights into diaspora-led crisis response mechanisms. The study highlights how CRs' tacit knowledge and cultural understanding can be systematically incorporated into research design, challenging conventional notions of researcher bias. We contribute to HCI and crisis informatics by proposing a framework for methodological innovation in community-based research, offering design recommendations for reframing methodological autonomy, leveraging complex identities, and integrating technology in culturally appropriate ways.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → User studies.

Keywords

diaspora, humanitarianism, citizen science, community research

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1 Introduction

Diaspora communities have long played a pivotal role in shaping transnational connections. The intersection of rapid globalisation and digital evolution has amplified the presence and scale of diaspora populations around the world. As migration patterns evolve and the concepts of citizenship and national identity become more complex, understanding the behaviours and identities of these communities is increasingly relevant [10]. This study examines the intersections of diaspora and humanitarian action, with a focus on the methodological value of involving diaspora community researchers (CRs). The digital evolution has been a crucial enabler for diaspora involvement in crises in their home countries, opening new avenues for studying diaspora humanitarian response [22]. However, traditional research methodologies often fall short in capturing the nuanced experiences of these communities. To address this gap, we adopted a community-based research (CBR) approach [12, 27], with eight CRs from diverse diaspora backgrounds to investigate crisis response within their communities.

Our study addresses two primary research questions:

- (1) How do diaspora CRs adapt and innovate research methodologies to effectively engage with their communities in the context of crisis response?
- (2) What insights can be gained from the experiences of diaspora CRs to inform future CBR practices in HCI and crisis informatics?

By leveraging the expertise and positionality of the CRs, we uncovered nuanced insights into processes and methodologies for engaging diaspora communities. Our primary contributions are:

- (1) Design recommendations for engaging CRs, leveraging complex identities, and integrating technology in culturally appropriate ways within community contexts.
- (2) Discussions on methodological innovation in CBR, highlighting how CRs' tacit knowledge and cultural understanding can be systematically incorporated into research design.

2 Related Work

This section examines two critical areas relevant to our research: the evolving role of diaspora communities in humanitarian responses and foundational principles of community-based research (CBR).

2.1 Diaspora Communities and Humanitarian Response

Diaspora populations have become pivotal actors in humanitarian crises, extending their roles beyond economic benefactors [13]. In addition to sending remittances [20], they now act as advocates and information conduits during crises [15, 22]. For instance, Armouch et al. demonstrate how the Lebanese diaspora used social media and digital platforms to mobilise advocacy efforts during the 2019 uprisings [2]. This activism underscores the diaspora's role in addressing systemic issues in Lebanon while navigating the complexities of transnational identities and relationships.

Similarly, studies have shown that beyond using digital media to send remittances, diaspora communities disseminate information, advocate for change, and protest on behalf of affected populations in their home countries online [4, 5, 11, 15]. The Ukrainian crisis further exemplifies this phenomenon, as diaspora communities strategically used digital networks for advocacy, relaying critical information, providing financial support, and participating in volunteer efforts to coordinate activism at a global scale [5, 6].

These examples highlight the multifaceted contributions of diaspora communities in humanitarian responses. As influential actors, they not only provide material aid but shape the discourse and dynamics of crises through advocacy and digital engagement.

2.2 Community-Based Research

Community-based research (CBR), or Community-based Participatory Research (CBPR), has a rich history [12, 18, 26], emerging as a response to traditional research practices that often failed to address the needs of marginalised and developing populations [9, 18, 27]. CBR prioritises methodologies that amplify the needs and voices of the communities involved, contrasting with traditional approaches that frequently produce academic knowledge with little tangible benefit or preservation of insights for the community [3, 16, 18].

In HCI, there has been growing interest in CBR for its ability to integrate community perspectives into research processes and artefact development, enhancing relevance and impact [1, 7, 25]. While CBR enables richer, more nuanced insights, CRs often face the challenge of balancing their dual roles as community insiders and academic researchers, which can create tensions between their personal affiliations and professional responsibilities [16]. Addressing these complexities, recent work advocates for study designs that reduce administrative burdens on CRs while fostering their autonomy to share ideas authentically [17], thereby respecting their unique positionality and enriching research outcomes. In the context of diaspora research, Awori's study on the Kenyan diaspora in Australia illustrates the value of 'in-group' researchers, whose cultural understanding facilitates effective code-switching and fosters authentic dialogue. Their deep familiarity with community norms enables the generation of contextually nuanced insights into diaspora experiences [3].

Despite the importance of both diaspora studies and CBR in HCI, the intersection of these fields remains underexplored. Our research aims to address this gap, examining the unique challenges of diaspora research and laying a foundation for further exploration of these concepts in other contexts.

3 Study Design

Our study employed a CBR approach, engaging eight diaspora-based CRs to examine their communities' responses to humanitarian crises in their home countries. This section outlines the process of CR engagement, along with our data collection and analysis procedures. We summarise the participatory design methods used by the CRs here, but reserve a more nuanced discussion of their application and limitations for the findings.

3.1 Project Overview

The project began in 2021 with the formation of an Advisory Board and the finalisation of the research team. Ethics approval was secured in early 2022, followed by the recruitment of CRs, who worked from May to November. Data collection concluded in October, and a synthesis workshop was held on November 6. In July 2024, a follow-up focus group reengaged CRs to reflect on the methodology and their experiences.

3.2 Researcher Training and Engagement

3.2.1 Selection and recruitment. We employed a multi-channel recruitment strategy, circulating calls through the Diaspora Action Network and refugee support organisations, including the Refugee Council and Settlement Services International Limited (SSI). We also leveraged personal networks within culture-specific communities. Out of a total of 60 applications received, 16 were shortlisted for interviews, and eight CRs were selected to join the final research team. The CRs were assessed based on their demonstrated engagement and embeddedness within their respective diaspora communities, their involvement in crisis response activities, and their access to community networks responding at the ground level. Another key criterion was strong communication skills, both in English and in one or more languages spoken within their communities. This enabled effective trust-building within the communities and ensured a smooth flow of information between the research team and participants.

3.2.2 Introductory training. The key researcher training activity, a two-day co-design workshop, was conducted in May 2022. We introduced researchers to co-design to emphasise the community-centric nature of the research and the value of their experiences in shaping the outcomes of the study. This approach also highlighted how methods could be adapted when working with communities, providing an accessible entry point for our CRs, none of whom had prior formal research experience.

- **High-level concept introductions:** An overview of the study's overarching aim, examining the role of diaspora in supporting crisis response in their home countries. Participants were introduced to the key concepts within the study, and to the foundations of co-design.
- **Collective definitions:** A collaborative effort to define the terms 'diaspora', 'crisis' and 'community'. This process involved mapping exercises to establish a shared theoretical foundation for the research.
- **Research methods and ethics:** Introductions to fundamental research methods for engaging with community participants. This section of the training also addressed ethical

Table 1: Overview of participants, represented diaspora, crises investigated, and a brief summary of each CR's selected research methodology

Participant	Country	Crisis investigated
P1	Afghanistan	Fall of Afghanistan to the Taliban in August 2021
P2	Syria	Economic crisis after the 2011 civil war, exacerbated by the 2020 Caesar Act
P3	South Sudan	The Abyei Border Crisis: Ongoing sporadic attacks by Misseriya militia and Sudanese forces
P4	Myanmar	Military coup on 1st February 2021
P5	Indonesia	Community response to COVID-19 in Indonesia across 2021-2022
P6	Lebanon	Impact of the 1975 to 1990 Civil War
P7	Nepal	7.8 Earthquake 2015
P8	Pasifika (Fiji, Tonga, Samoa)	Tsunami from a volcanic eruption – Tonga, January 15, 2022

considerations, including data ownership and the responsibilities associated with data collection and use. Key elements included:

- Introductions to basic research methods such as interviews, surveys, and focus groups and how to select methods based on hypothetical scenarios.
- Provision of templates and samples for various research tools, including surveys, in-depth interviews, focus groups, researcher diaries, consent forms, plain-language explanatory statements.
- Guidance on managing ethical dilemmas, data ownership, and understanding the roles and access levels of the research team.

3.2.3 Ongoing support. Following the introductory co-design workshop, researchers had one month to develop their plans with ongoing support from the team. Advisory Board members provided feedback in individual meetings in May and June before data collection began. The research team maintained a supportive role, offering guidance to the CR team if needed. A mid-point feedback meeting was held in July, followed by individual CR interviews and a sense-making workshop in November to synthesise findings.

3.3 Data Collection and Analysis

In this study, the research team focused on extracting key qualitative insights from the researcher engagement process. This included meta-data such as feedback, observations, and contextual information gathered while supporting and reviewing the researchers' work. The two primary sources of data included interviews and a focus group:

- **Interviews:** Individual, in-depth interviews were conducted with each CR by a member of the research team in October and November 2022, following completion of the data collection process. These interviews concentrated on their findings related to diaspora crisis response, however, the meta-data generated during these interviews provided crucial context and depth to the qualitative findings.
- **Focus group:** In July 2024, we held a focus group with the CRs to gain a deeper understanding of their methodological approaches and the practical aspects of their implementation. Six of the eight CRs attended. The focus group was largely unstructured, with a few key themes identified from the interview metadata used to guide the reflection.

Initial interview transcripts were coded to identify foundational themes that shaped the focus group discussions. Focus group data was then transcribed and analysed in NVivo to generate codes. Consultations with the lead researchers who had guided the project since inception framed the thematic analysis across both data sources.

4 Findings

Our analysis of the metadata and subsequent focus group discussions unveiled three interconnected themes that characterised the experiences of the CRs:

4.1 Impact of Community Dynamics on Research Practices

Community dynamics shaped CRs' practices, requiring them to draw on tacit knowledge and adapt research methods to meet their communities' needs, adjusting their engagement strategies iteratively.

4.1.1 Methodological adaptations. Although each CR initially drafted a research plan with the support of the research team, most made significant modifications during data collection, adapting in real time to community interactions. P2's experience highlighted the tension between predetermined research methodologies and culturally responsive community outreach, sharing *Sometimes, while interviewing someone online, the wife would join in and start participating, or there would be multiple people involved in the interview even though I had scheduled it with only one. I had chosen to interview either the wife or the husband specifically to account for factors like diversity, age, or education... but out of courtesy, I had to continue with both.* This illustrated a divergence between the structured expectations of traditional research paradigms and the culturally embedded dynamics of participant interaction.

Similarly, P8 faced methodological challenges that led to a significant shift in their data collection approach, explaining, *It started as a survey in front of people, and it ended up becoming a discussion or a session around it. So, one survey was responded to by three or four people in that sitting. The understanding of the question and the context of the questioning, and also how they understood the question, meant that the response was more like the agreement reached after discussing.* P8 linked this to the concept of Talanoa, a Pacific

Table 2: An overview of key themes that emerged from the findings

Theme	Description
Impact of Community Dynamics on Research Practices	The social structures and cultural norms within communities influenced how CRs approached and conducted their research.
Navigation of Multifaceted Identities	CRs balanced their community insider status with research responsibilities, managing complex relationships and cultural perspectives.
Dynamic Adaptation of Technology	CRs adjusted the level of use of digital tools to match community preferences and used them dynamically for their own research needs.

form of dialogue [23, 28], demonstrating how the evolving engagement style reflected the participants' cultural approach to collective decision-making.

Such adaptations often led to unexpected insights and challenges. For instance, P3 encountered difficulties in engaging younger community members, noting, *The youth never called me for the meetings. They only come to the community meetings when they are called by the leaders.* This highlighted the complexities of community engagement, especially across generational divides, and the influence of traditional leadership structures on research participation. Overall, CRs emphasized the complex interplay between research methodologies and community norms, illustrating how their nuanced understanding of cultural practices led to continual adjustments in their research processes.

4.2 Managing trust and relationships

CRs also faced challenges fostering open and honest dialogue. Their status as community insiders presented both advantages and challenges in this context. While their insider status could facilitate a level of trust and familiarity, it also inhibited open communication. Some participants hesitated to share thoughts or experiences with a CR from their own community, fearing judgment. P2 shared, *I think...it's an advantage and disadvantage to be from your own community, because sometimes they afraid to tell you what they think of, because it's shaming.* This fear of judgment or repercussions within the community hindered participants' willingness to share openly. As P2 elucidated: *So this is, make them fear, more especially mentioning anything related to government or to religion, or even to talk about their own family circumstances.*

Despite these barriers, CRs' efforts to foster open dialogue and build trust helped strengthen relationships with some community members. As P7 noted, *It did really help strengthen even the existing connections that I had... having to sit down with one particular individual and discuss a particular topic, made me feel like I bonded with that person a lot more.* These efforts played a crucial role in overcoming initial reluctance and creating space for more candid exchanges. P8's experience as a Samoan researcher with the Tongan diaspora further illustrated this evolution. P8's said: *The community that the research was based on was the Tongan community, which I had very little contact with. However, during, after, and until now, I have met quite a lot of them and continue to engage with them in various community works,* highlighting how continuous outreach efforts facilitated deeper connections.

4.3 Navigating Complex Identities

The relational dynamics between CRs and their communities shaped the research experience. CRs navigated their dual roles, focusing on: (i) balancing in-group identity with biases from personal and community perceptions, and (ii) the tension between their roles as academic researchers and community insiders.

4.3.1 Navigating in-group identities. CRs faced challenges due to their in-group status, managing the tension between personal beliefs and the biases arising from their dual roles. This required balancing their insider preconceptions with the expectations and assumptions of community members who viewed them through the lens of cultural affiliation.

P1's experience highlighted the emotional toll: *One of the other challenges was my own trauma. It was a huge one before I realised it. It was overwhelmingly beyond what I imagined it would be.* This tension was compounded by cultural identity dynamics, as P1 elucidated, *I said 'Afghanistani diaspora' instead of 'Afghan.' And he had an extreme reaction to me, saying, 'You're being divisive.'* This revealed diversity of perspectives within communities, and how bilateral trauma, cultural and emotional tensions, made insider research particularly challenging.

P6 also noted the assumptions others made based on their name, origin, and language, saying, *From the beginning of reaching out to someone, they will have assumptions about you... you have to navigate these assumptions to get the answers you want.* P4 echoed this, commenting on the difficulty of maintaining neutrality, saying, *I think it is hard to be neutral when facilitating or asking questions because people already know who you are and what you stand for.* These insights underscored the need for CRs to account for biases and assumptions throughout the research process to ensure effective engagement.

4.3.2 Navigating researcher identities. CRs also faced challenges balancing their roles as academic researchers and community insiders. They needed to maintain authentic community engagement while ensuring research rigor, particularly when bridging academic and community contexts: *If someone can't really articulate themselves in an academic way, or like, my parents who can't speak English, you need to be able to connect with them as well in terms of how they're responding. You need to be able to connect.*

In conjunction, some CRs leveraged their academic affiliations to enhance their data collection efforts. This approach proved particularly effective in addressing challenges related to in-group dynamics, where community members' hesitancy sometimes limited access. By emphasising their academic affiliation, CRs were able to bolster the credibility of their research and foster greater trust

within the community. P2 shared, *I think the branding played a role. Knowing it's Melbourne University, and you know, the university is well-respected, I think, from the community. So they were willing to share.* The navigation of researcher identity could serve to counterbalance in-group identity issues, supporting the trust-building process in some instances.

4.4 Dynamic Adaption of Technology

Researchers encountered varied digital adoption across communities, adapting technology to meet their needs and exploring innovative integration to enhance their research.

4.4.1 Diverse participant perspectives on technology. CRs reported variance in attitudes and practices around technology across diaspora populations. The COVID-19 pandemic accelerated the adoption of online research methods in some communities: *I think, since COVID-19 in the Nepali community as well, a lot of programs were held online... so our community has really adjusted into this new virtual world,* said P7. Other CRs emphasised the nuanced use of technology within their communities, highlighting the crucial role of CRs who understood these dynamics. As P6 noted regarding the Pacific community: *The older community members use Facebook, while the younger ones prefer Instagram.*

The efficacy of integrating technology in research practices varied significantly across contexts, revealing nuanced challenges in building trust and eliciting meaningful participation. Some CRs found that establishing rapport and credibility necessitated more traditional, personalised communication methods. P6 shared, *Sometimes, I have to call a person like five or six times until we agree on time, because it is cause I'm trying to just to build a trust with this person. If I keep it on messages or keeping technology, the person will not trust me much.* P4 corroborated these findings, noting limited success with digital approaches, sharing that a digital survey yielded poor response rates, whereas participants were *happy to answer on paper*. These reflections indicated that the willingness to engage with technology in research contexts varied depending on the specific sociocultural environment of the diaspora community, which necessitated careful consideration and adaption of digital engagement strategies.

4.4.2 Innovative CR applications of technology. Conversely, CRs adapted technology to suit their own needs in a way that was not prescribed or anticipated by the research team. Throughout the data collection process, researchers creatively modified their use of technology to better meet their own needs and address the specific contexts of their communities. *I think technology was really a game changer as well. It was the first time I've actually recorded interviews. That was so good, like learning that during the research, and that is now a skill I'm using,* said P8, noting that the techniques shared by the research team allowed her to streamline her ways of working. Other CRs reported innovative use of technology as well. P5 described using her phone to reduce the work burden of keeping a research diary, saying, *In a way, [the diary] feels like it's writing a report... We have to do a lot more work. I like to record it on my phone while I have that. And I actually don't write it down.* CRs also considered that adapting technology dynamically could enhance their connection with communities. P6 said, *When we sent*

out our information packets, they were massive documents to read. I think that for me, using more technology—such as audio or video explanations of the research—would be very helpful. This observation underscored a critical intersection between technology and inclusive research practices, a perspective particularly well understood by CRs. It aligned with previous discussions regarding CRs' extensive knowledge of their communities' technological engagement and usage and reflected their efforts to democratise their research by engaging with a diverse range of community members.

5 Design Recommendations

5.1 Navigating Autonomy in the Implementation of Established Research Methods

Our findings demonstrated that CRs consistently adapted their research approaches in response to community dynamics, adjusting traditional methods for data collection to accommodate participation in a way that reflected cultural communication norms and collective decision-making processes. We advocate a shift away from prescriptive methodologies toward co-created frameworks that empower greater autonomy and adaptability in research design. Researchers should collaborate with community members from the outset to develop methodologies that are contextually appropriate and align with community values and communication styles [14, 19]. For example, practices like Talanoa, an alternative methodology rooted in Pacific communities, demonstrate the value of culturally attuned approaches but remain underutilised in HCI research [28].

Co-designing research protocols with community input builds on the success of participatory design in HCI [21], extending it to methodological development. Incorporating indigenous knowledge systems and community practices can yield culturally sensitive methods for knowledge elicitation and co-creation. Digital platforms could further facilitate this process by enabling real-time collaboration, iterative dialogue, and the ongoing adaptation of methodologies throughout the research lifecycle.

5.2 Leveraging Community Identities to Innovate Methodological Approaches

Relatedly, we suggest an identity-conscious approach to research design that recognises researchers' multifaceted identities and positionality as integral components of the research process. As our study revealed, CRs navigated complex landscapes, balancing their insider status with research responsibilities while managing assumptions based on their cultural affiliations and perceived neutrality within their communities. Rather than viewing researcher bias as a limitation, this perspective reframes it as an asset, one that, when strategically engaged, deepens insights and enriches the research process.

Reflexive tools, such as digital identity mapping exercises inspired by social identity mapping [8], can help researchers engage with their positionality and understand how their identities shape the research. Collaborative platforms might support dialogue among researchers, fostering spontaneous community of practice around identity-conscious research.

Exploring the incorporation of identity-based methodological innovations into research training could also offer value. This could involve supporting researchers in leveraging their insider knowledge and cultural understanding to deepen their investigations, similar to the way in which CRs in our study utilised their dual identities — researcher and community member — to elicit more meaningful engagement where appropriate. Drawing from HCI approaches to designing for diverse user groups [24], researchers could be guided in crafting research personas that engage various facets of their identity. This would enhance rapport, facilitate insight generation, and lead to more culturally sensitive, contextually grounded methodologies that challenge traditional notions of objectivity.

5.3 Revisiting Digital Processes in Community Research

In line with our earlier recommendations on co-created methodologies and identity-conscious research, we propose an adaptive approach to integrating technology into CBR. From the outset, researchers should anticipate diverse data types, extending beyond traditional methods to include audio, visual, and other non-textual formats that reflect community communication preferences. This recommendation is directly informed by our study findings, where CRs demonstrated varying levels of technology engagement across communities and innovatively adapted digital tools to better serve both their own research processes and community preferences—recording interviews instead of taking notes, considering multimedia formats for information sharing, and recognizing the limitations of technology when building trust required more traditional communication methods.

Awori et al.'s work on transnational research [3] supports this perspective by emphasising the use of familiar, non-invasive technologies, that are already integrated into the community's daily life to preserve the authenticity of participants' contributions, ensuring that technology enhances the research process without disrupting the natural flow of community engagement. By adopting practices and tools that support this technological diversity, researchers can collect and integrate data in various formats tailored to the preferences and practices of community members. This flexible approach ensures that technology remains an enabler of rich, contextually grounded data.

6 Conclusions

This study examined methodological innovations emerging from diaspora CRs approaches to investigating crisis response within their communities. Analysis of eight researchers' experiences revealed key themes: the impact of community dynamics on research practices, navigation of multifaceted identities, and dynamic adaptation of technology. The findings demonstrate how CRs adapted methods to align with cultural norms, navigated insider-outsider dynamics, and tailored technology use to community needs. This work contributes insights into methodological innovation in CBR and offers recommendations for leveraging CRs' unique positions, with implications for HCI researchers working with diverse communities in crisis response contexts.

7 Limitations and future work

We recognise key limitations of our work. The considerable time between our initial data collection and follow-up focus group on methodology was necessitated by project timelines and CR availability, as they remained actively involved in their communities and ongoing projects. This gap may have introduced retrospective bias regarding their methodological reflections. Our sample of eight CRs, while representative of diverse diaspora communities, limits generalisability of our findings. Future work might explore methodological innovations with a larger sample across more communities. The design recommendations presented within this paper serve as a foundation for further exploration. Related areas for examination might include the development of novel methodological frameworks to better support identity-conscious research across diverse transnational communities.

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